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TALKING TO HER OWN IMAGE

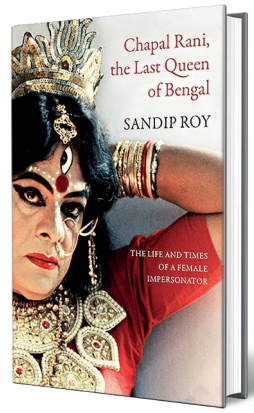
THROUGH THE LIFE OF BENGAL'S LAST GREAT FEMALE IMPERSONATOR, SANDIP ROY OFFERS A POIGNANT, LAYERED PORTRAIT OF *JATRA*, GENDER AND QUEERNESS

AT FIRST GLANCE, SANDIP ROY'S *Chapal Rani, the Last Queen of Bengal: The Life and Times of a Female Impersonator* is an oral autobiography narrated in the lamenting voice of Chapal Bhaduri to Roy over hundreds of cups of tea. Bhaduri shot to fame as his stage avatar, Chapal Rani, in the 1960s because of his roles playing women on stage in *jatra* (Bengali folk theatre). At the time, this was common practice. His recollections are filled with beautifully filigreed descriptions of his life in the world of *jatra*, his physical transformation into being a woman on stage, and his life lived as a male-presenting person, with a bisexual male lover, outside of it. His fame fades away, though, when women enter the stage in greater numbers and he is suddenly left unemployed and penniless. For a while, he lives off the kindness of others or by performing street theatre. In later years, he acquires a different kind of notoriety—as a Bengali queer icon, ceremoniously feted at times, who performs versions of his own biography repeatedly on stage, television and film, before eventually settling into a lonely and modest life in an old-age home.

The book is not flawless. It is unnecessarily long. Some details are extraordinarily boring, such as Bhaduri's psyllium husk regimen. But nothing is as boring as Bhaduri's views on his own gender identity, which will cure even the most unyielding insomnia. ("I am not third gender. I am first gender", etc.)

But, all of this is offset by its strengths, chief among which is a dialectical exchange interlaced with the autobiography. It unfolds between Bhaduri, raconteur par excellence, who is finally telling his version of his own story—in searing defiance of the acclaimed film director Rituparno Ghosh's absurd attempt to hijack it in the 2010 film, *Arekti Premer Golpo*—and his interlocutor, Roy. Roy, in turn, deftly injects into the text perspectives that differ, at times sharply, from the narrator's. The result is a 'cubist' text that is fascinating, edifying and skilfully executed, without denuding the protagonist of his dignity. Roy accomplishes this with an unusual technique: interspersing the narrative with a series of 'interludes', several of which are 'imaginary' counter-narratives, written in the voices of characters that interact with Bhaduri in different ways. Many of these are gut-wrenchingly poignant, but the ending of 'The Ghost of Putulbari' will disassemble your soul. ■

—Cyril Ghosh



CHAPAL RANI, THE LAST QUEEN OF BENGAL: The Life and Times of a Female Impersonator
by SANDIP ROY
SEAGULL BOOKS
₹999; 532 pages

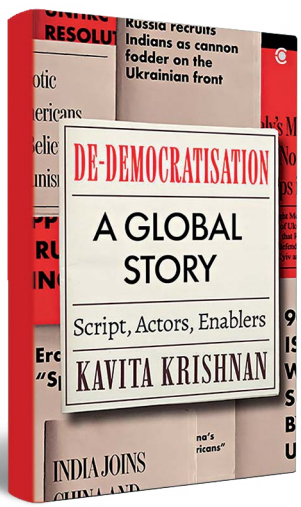
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